



ELECTION COMMISSION, DELHI

FIRST UMPIRE

ULTIMATE REFEREE *Sceptical of Jawaharlal Nehru's plan to hold elections in the spring of 1951, the then chief election commissioner Sukumar Sen insisted on delaying things till early 1952 because of heavy preparations needed for the elections.*

"The electoral methods have added resilience to India's democratic credentials."

N. GOPALASWAMI,
CHIEF ELECTION COMMISSIONER

Guiding the country's chaotic democracy for decades, the Election Commission (EC) has been the country's foremost referee. Held in 1952, the first general elections were a mammoth exercise with 4,500 seats at stake of which 500 were reserved for Parliament and 4,000 for provisional assemblies. According to the then chief election commissioner (CEC) Sukumar Sen, the politicians and the public were "essentially law-abiding and peaceful" with 817 cases of impersonation of voters and 106 attempts to take the ballot boxes out of polling stations. Indians were curious participants in the maiden carnival of democracy. A booth in a tribal district in Assam had 70 per cent turnout while a neighbouring booth had an elephant and a panther as the only visitors.

In the years to come, the EC's role was to be put under the scanner. It turned into a spectator, at times moonlighting as a benefactor of consecutive Congress governments. But things changed in

1991, when T.N. Seshan took over as the CEC. Under him, the EC went far beyond election statutes to check candidates who made their pitch on divisive grounds.

The first general elections weren't quite a honeymoon period for the EC. It was forced to strike off the names of almost 2.8 million women voters after many in north India refused to add their names to the voters' list and wanted to be identified as somebody's wife or sister. Infuriated by their demands, Sen let them stay away from the elections. However, when India went for the polls last time, the electoral roll saw 282 million women voters gleefully posing for photo-identity cards which carried their first names.

When adult suffrage was introduced, many called it a "gamble" for the country because of widespread illiteracy, caste system and other social ills. Decades later, India is a vibrant democracy and the EC has played a vital role in helping it on its journey.

by Shafi Rahman



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